



▽ Jibbeh (tunic) worn by Mahdists, c. 1880

1883

MAHDISTS FIGHT AN ANGLO-EGYPTIAN ARMY IN SUDAN

In 1881, Islamic cleric Muhammad Ahmad declared himself Mahdi (spiritual leader) and led an uprising against Egypt, which had controlled Sudan since 1819. In 1883, Egyptian and British forces were defeated by the Mahdists at El Obeid. Khartoum fell to the Mahdists in 1885.



△ Mahdists clash with British forces

1884

1882 Anti-Jewish pogroms

occur in Russia, following the assassination of Tsar Alexander, which was blamed on the Jews



1883

KRAKATOA ERUPTS IN INDONESIA

From 20 May 1883, the volcanic island of Krakatoa, between Java and Sumatra, began erupting for the first time in 200 years. In August, a series of four explosions almost completely destroyed the island. Eruptions sent vast quantities of earth into the air, created vast tsunamis, and killed 36,000 people.



△ Delegates at the Berlin conference

1884

EUROPEAN POWERS DIVIDE UP AFRICA

Marking a new stage in their imperialist ambitions, European powers met in Berlin in November 1884 to effectively partition Africa into European colonies. Organized by German chancellor Otto von Bismarck, the conference continued until February 1885. Some 14 nations attended, including France, Belgium, Portugal, and Britain. No African leaders were consulted or invited to attend, nor was any consideration given to existing cultural, social, ethnic, and language borders. Within a few years, European powers controlled more than 80 per cent of Africa.